participate in secretive forums, which mitigate the domestic costs of IO cooperation. In contrast, nonpopulist leaders, whose constituencies are less critical of IO engagement, often find secrecy unnecessary.

Covert and overt engagement with IOs can function as either complementary or substitutive strategies. Nonpopulist leaders, for example, may combine public and private channels to maximize the benefits of IO membership. Populist leaders, however, face higher domestic costs for overt engagement because of their anti-elite rhetoric. As a result, we hypothesize that populists are more likely to substitute overt cooperation with private participation.

This hypothesis aligns with evidence from previous chapters. In chapter 3, we demonstrated that populist leaders initiate fewer IMF programs publicly than nonpopulist leaders. This chapter shows that such leaders are more likely to leverage behind-the-scenes methods of engagement. Together, these findings suggest that populist governments rely more heavily on covert multilateral cooperation, opting for private channels to balance the benefits of IO engagement against their need to appear anti-IO.

6.3 Empirical Analysis: Testing Populist Reliance on Private IMF Participation

Tracking secrecy in IOs is inherently challenging, as covert interactions are, by definition, designed to escape detection. However, novel data from the IMF offer a unique lens into these behind-the-scenes engagements. This section leverages that data, introduced in Carnegie, Clark, and Kaya (2024), to analyze covert participation.

Focusing on the IMF allows for a systematic exploration of covert engagement within a normatively and substantively significant institution. As discussed in chapter 2, the IMF is a cornerstone of global economic governance, shaping states' economic policies through loans, surveillance, and technical assistance. Its visibility and influence make it particularly salient for both populist and nonpopulist leaders. For many countries, the IMF serves as a lender of last resort, providing essential financial and technical support during crises (Vreeland 2005; Kentikelenis, Stubbs, and King 2016).